

distinctive New Orleans Voudon developed, which was much more overtly magical in its beliefs and practices. One of the most famous 19th-century practitioners was Marie Laveau, a hairdresser turned Voudon-savant. By the end of her life, she was widely regarded as the “Voodoo Queen of New Orleans,” a healer, hexer, and fortune-teller, consulted by the highest and the lowest of the city. Her legacy survives today only in tourist-driven sales of Voodoo dolls.

The power of Hoodoo

Hoodoo was always different from Voudon. Where Voudon traces its origins to West Africa, and especially Dahomey (today’s Benin), Hoodoo is drawn from Central Africa, specifically the Congo. Its practitioners today can be found across the US, even if its roots remain in the Deep South with memories of slavery and oppression.

Hoodoo draws on a wide range of folk-magic sources. It is as indebted to the likes of Johann Hohman’s *Pow-Wows*; or *Long-Lost Friend* and to the mythical Sixth and Seventh Books of Moses (see pp.202–203) as it is to its African origins. From the natural world, Hoodoo makes use of herbs and roots—its practitioners are often called

“rootworkers”—of animal parts, and minerals, especially lodestones (minerals that are naturally magnetic). It also calls on an array of candles, oils, incense, and powders. Hoodoo holds out the promise of love and riches, and something for everyone. It offers cures and curses; good and bad luck. Its practitioners predict the future, using animal bones for divination, and also interpret dreams. Hoodoo is still fueled by proverbs and stories, and by a rich blend of ancient lore and claimed wisdom. It is a legacy of a much older world of folk magic distilled down the ages and across continents.

▲ Lucky root

The John the Conqueror root is particularly valued by practitioners of Hoodoo. It has been claimed both to bestow magical sexual potency and to ensure luck in gambling.



IN CONTEXT

West African links

Voudon may most obviously be associated with Haiti. However, it is still active in West Africa, particularly in Benin, where it originated in the Fon religion and where there are believed to be four million followers of Voudon today (see pp.292–293). This talismanic statue—a fetish, called a *bocio*—is typical. Its purpose is partly holistic, as a source of natural healing, and partly to protect its owner from evil outside forces. Although the *bocio* can be appealed to directly, with no priest as intermediary, certain blood sacrifices, typically of chickens or goats, are required to unleash its power. *Bocio* may be carved from bones, stones, or wood, and some are light enough to carry.

This Fon *bocio* is laden with powerful objects to protect its maker.

